

Acting in a different way

Some words add more than just detail. For example, the free morpheme and adjective *kind* can combine with the bound morpheme ending *-ness*, which forms the noun *kindness*. The meaning of a word can also change. For example, the word *helpful* can acquire the opposite meaning when the bound morpheme *un-* is added, which results in the word *unhelpful*.



• Understanding morphemes can help with unfamiliar words. Take **demagnetize**: the morpheme is the noun **magnet**, but the **suffix -ize** changes it to a verb. However, the newly created word **magnetize** acquires the opposite meaning when the **prefix de-** is added, and refers to the act of making something **less magnetic**.

Rule 1

The bound morpheme ending *-ness* changes an adjective into a noun.

bright / bright**ness**

It is very **bright** in this room.

This room's **brightness** is overwhelming.

Rule 2

The bound morpheme ending *-ion* changes a verb into a noun.

act / **action**

She wanted to **act** in the play.

The play contained many **action** scenes.

Rule 3

The bound morpheme *-ful* attaches to the end of a noun and changes it into an adjective.

spite / **spiteful**

The annoyed boy ignored his sister out of **spite**.

The **spiteful** boy became very annoyed.

Rule 4

The bound morpheme *un-* attaches to the start of a word to give it the opposite meaning.

helpful / **unhelpful**

The **helpful** boy carried the bags.

The **unhelpful** boy did not carry the bags.

In the field of linguistics, **morphology** is the identification, analysis, and description of words that **form a language**, including root words and parts of speech.